seemingly bad situation, Lynda was trying to break into the movie business by formulating the concepts for a movie called *Flashdance.*

The *Cosmos* premier was a black-tie event at the Griffith Observatory. Klutz that I was, I wore a baby-blue tuxedo. Everybody who was anybody in Los Angeles was there. I was completely out of my element, and had a glorious time.

For the next two years, Lynda and I dated on and off. But the chemistry just wasn't right. Her intensity enthralled and exhausted me. I debated whether the exhaustion was worth the highs, but the choice wasn't mine. Perhaps it was my velour shirts and double-knit pants; I don't know. Lynda soon lost romantic interest in me, but something better was growing: a lasting and creative friendship and partnership between two very different people, from very different worlds.

Fast-forward to October 2005, another of our occasional one-on-one dinners, where conversation would range from recent cosmological discoveries, to left-wing politics, to great food, to the shifting sands of moviemaking. Lynda by now was among Hollywood's most accomplished and versatile producers (*Flashdance, The Fisher King, Contact, How to Lose a Guy in Ten Days*). I had married. My wife, Carolee Winstein, had become best friends with Lynda. And I'd not done badly in the world of physics.

Over dinner, Lynda described an idea she had conceived for a science-fiction movie and asked me to help her flesh it out. This would be her second venture into science fiction: a collaboration with me, modeled on her previous collaboration with Carl Sagan on the movie *Contact.*

I never imagined myself helping create a movie. I never coveted a presence in Hollywood, beyond a vicarious one, through Lynda's adventures. But working with Lynda appealed to me, and her ideas